

Mom Test: Asking the Right Questions to Validate Your Idea

with Katya de Freedericksz

ABOUT ME

Katya de Freedericksz

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THE MOM TEST

How to talk to customers and learn
if your business is a good idea
when everyone is lying to you

"Once for ounce, there's no better way
to learn what customers want and will
buy than this wonderful little book. If you
want your new product or new business
to succeed, start here."

— John Mullins
Author of *The New
Business Road Test*

Rob Fitzpatrick THE MOM TEST



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THE





The Mom Test

How to learn from customers when everybody is lying to you

**You may love your mom
a lot but Never ask your
mom for product
feedback.**

Ask "how's my business idea?" and
your customers 'might' lie. Your
mom 'will' lie. Bad questions make
everyone lie to you at least a bit.

It's on you to dig for the truth to
evaluate your business idea. We do
that by asking good questions.

The Mom Test lays out simple rules
to craft good questions. Questions
even your mom can't lie to you
about.





To avoid building products that nobody wants, **ask the right questions** that uncover what customers truly need.



The Mom Test is a set of rules for asking questions in a way that even your mom can't give you misleading answers.

**PASSES THE
'MOM TEST'**

*questions
even your
mom won't lie
to you about*

Yup, she's likely going to lie when you ask "Mom, isn't this a great idea?"

**THEIR LIFE/
PROBLEMS**

*not ideas /
solutions but
day-to-day
inefficiencies*

Get them to do their tasks and observe the inefficiencies

**THE
PAST**

*not
hypotheticals
/ the future*

Problems they have actually encountered

**SPECIFIC
DETAILS**

*not generics /
vague
information*

No one was ever able to find a location with a 'maybe take a turn in a bit'.

Talk about their life instead of your idea;
Ask about specifics in the past instead of
generics or opinions about the future;
Talk less and listen more;

The Mom Test
Rob Fitzpatrick





**LET'S PRACTICE ASKING
QUESTIONS**

“Do you think it’s a good idea?”

“Do you think it’s a good idea?”



NO

Let's fix it: Say you're building an app to help construction companies manage their suppliers. You might ask them to show you how they currently do it.

Talk about which parts they love and hate. Ask which other tools and processes they tried before settling on this one. Are they actively searching for a replacement? If so, what's the sticking point? If not, why not? Where are they losing money with their current tools? Is there a budget for better ones?

"Would you buy a product which did X?"

"Would you buy a product which did X?"



NO

Let's fix it: Ask how they currently solve X and how much it costs them to do so. And how much time it takes. Ask them to talk you through what happened the last time X came up. If they haven't solved the problem, ask why not. Have they tried searching for solutions and found them wanting? Or do they not even care enough to have Googled for it?

"How much would you pay for X?"

"How much would you pay for X?"



NO

How to fix it: Just like the others, fix it by asking about their life as it already is. How much does the problem cost them? How much do they currently pay to solve it? How big is the budget they've allocated? I hope you're noticing a trend here.

"Talk me through the last time that happened."

"Talk me through the last time that happened."



YES

How to fix it: Just like the others, fix it by asking about their life as it already is. How much does the problem cost them? How much do they currently pay to solve it? How big is the budget they've allocated? I hope you're noticing a trend here.

"What else have you tried?"

"What else have you tried?"



YES

"Would you pay X for a product which did Y?"

"Would you pay X for a product which did Y?"



Let's fix it: As always, ask about what they already do now, not what they believe they might do in the future. Common wisdom is that you price your product in terms of value to the customer rather than cost to you. That's true. And you can't quantify the value received without prodding their financial worldview.

**How much would you pay for
X? — Bad question!**

**Would you buy a product
which did X? — Bad question!**

**Do you think it's a good idea?!
— Bad question!**

✗ Bad Question

1. Would you use this if we built it?

2. Do you like the idea?

3. How much would you pay for this?

4. Would this be useful to you?

5. Do you think others would be interested?

✓ Better Version

Can you walk me through the last time you faced this problem?

What have you tried so far to solve this? How did it work for you?

Have you paid for something similar before? How much did it cost you?

Tell me about a time when you really needed a solution for this. What did you do?

Have you seen colleagues or friends struggle with this? What did they do about it?

There are three types of bad data:

1. Compliments
2. Fluff (generics, hypotheticals, and the future)
3. Ideas

Anchoring fluff

Fluff comes in 3 cuddly shapes:

- Generic claims (“I usually”, “I always”, “I never”)
- Future-tense promises (“I would”, “I will”)
- Hypothetical maybes (“I might”, “I could”)

Transitioning from a fluffy question to a concrete one:

You : “Do you ever X?” *A fluff-inducing question.*

Them: “Oh yeah, all the time.” *A fluffy answer which has no value in itself, but which we can anchor from.*

You : “When’s the last time that happened?” *We use The Mom Test and ask for a concrete example in the past.*

Them: “Two weekends ago.” *We’ve successfully anchored the fluff and are now ready to get real facts instead of generics and hypotheticals.*

You : “Can you talk me through that?” *Back to asking good questions.*

BEFORE

If you haven't yet, choose a focused, findable segment

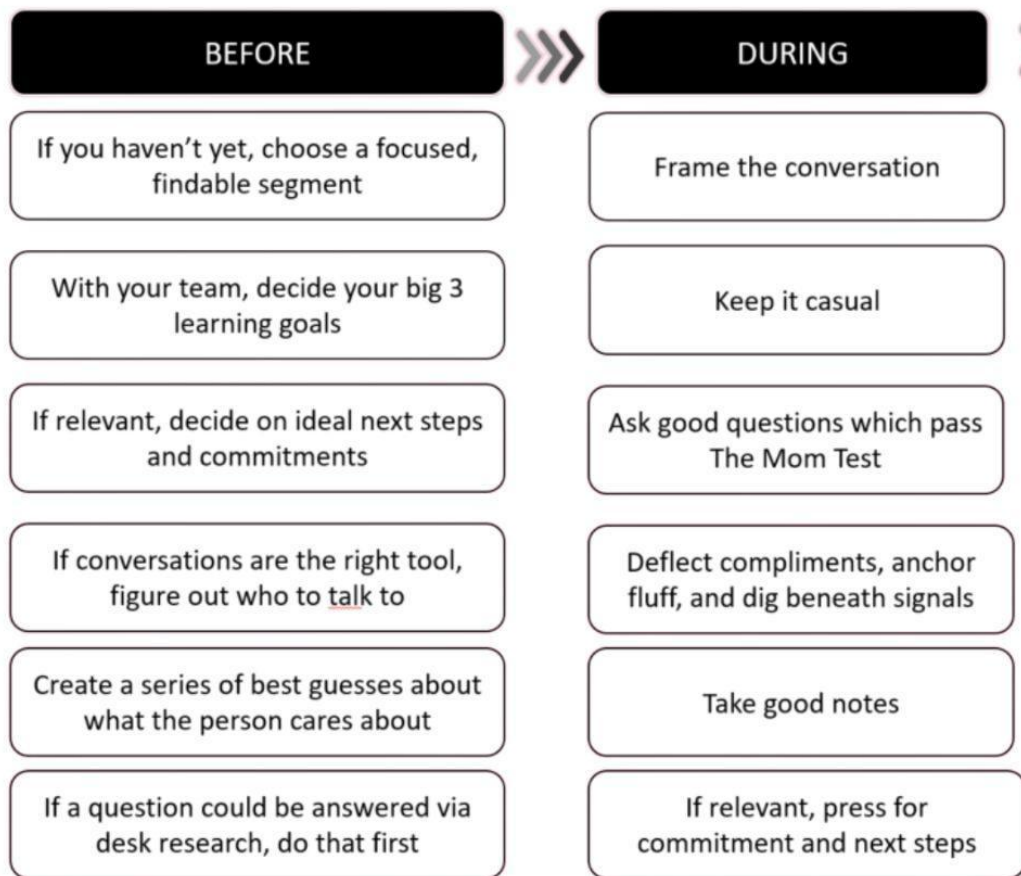
With your team, decide your big 3 learning goals

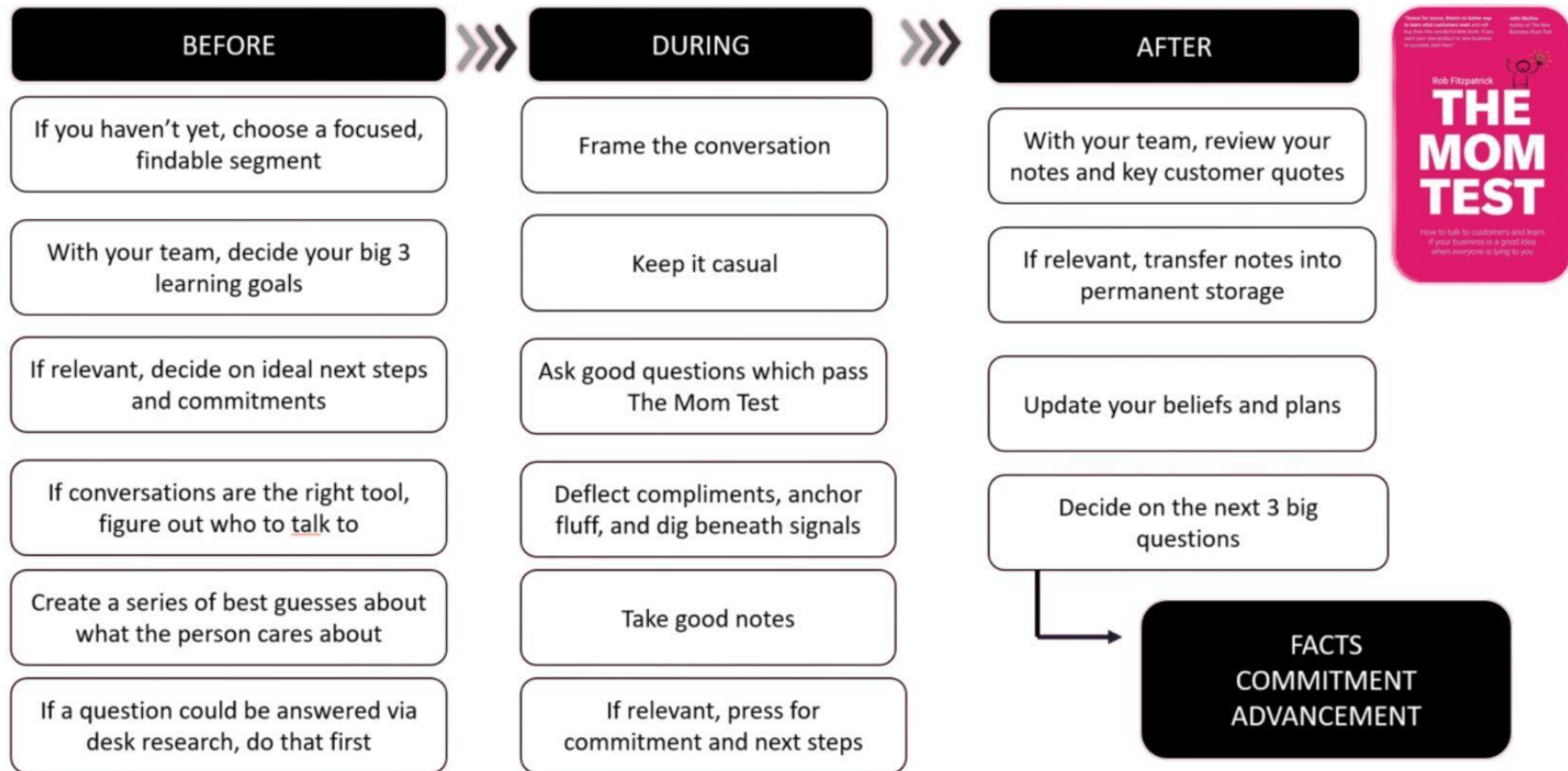
If relevant, decide on ideal next steps and commitments

If conversations are the right tool, figure out who to talk to

Create a series of best guesses about what the person cares about

If a question could be answered via desk research, do that first





HOW, WHEN & WHY CONDUCT INTERVIEWS

BEFORE

If you haven't yet, choose a focused, findable segment

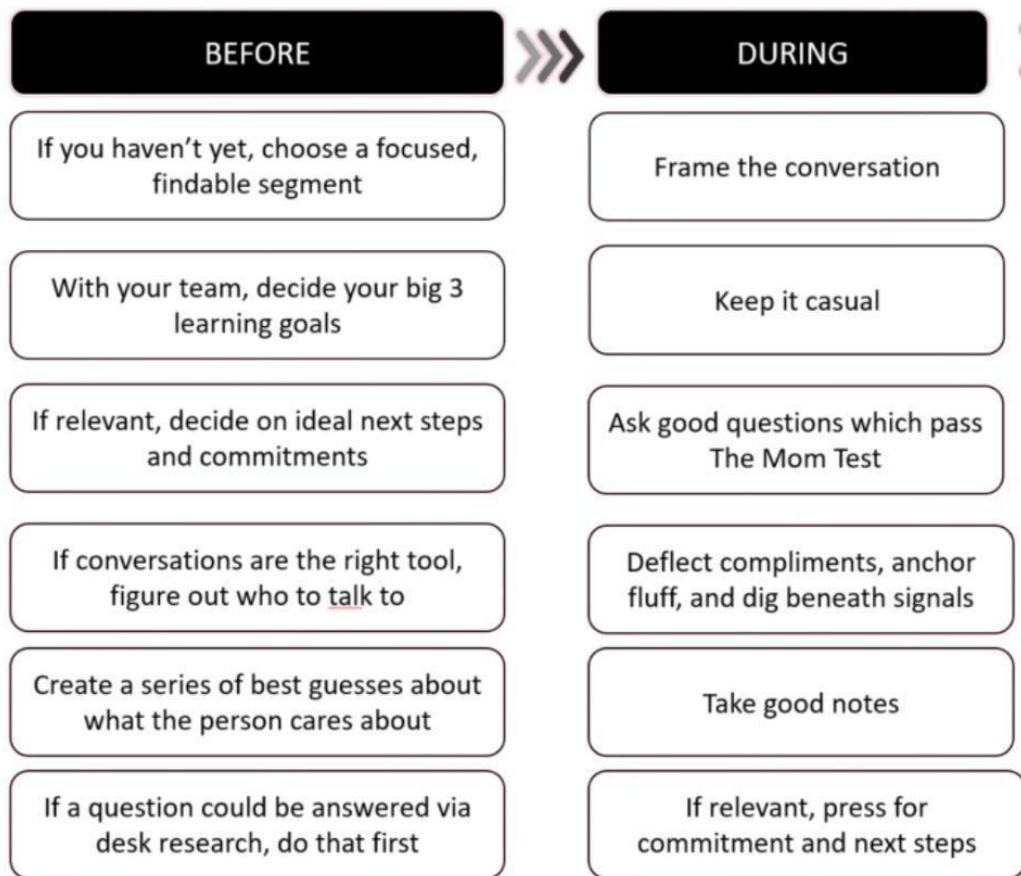
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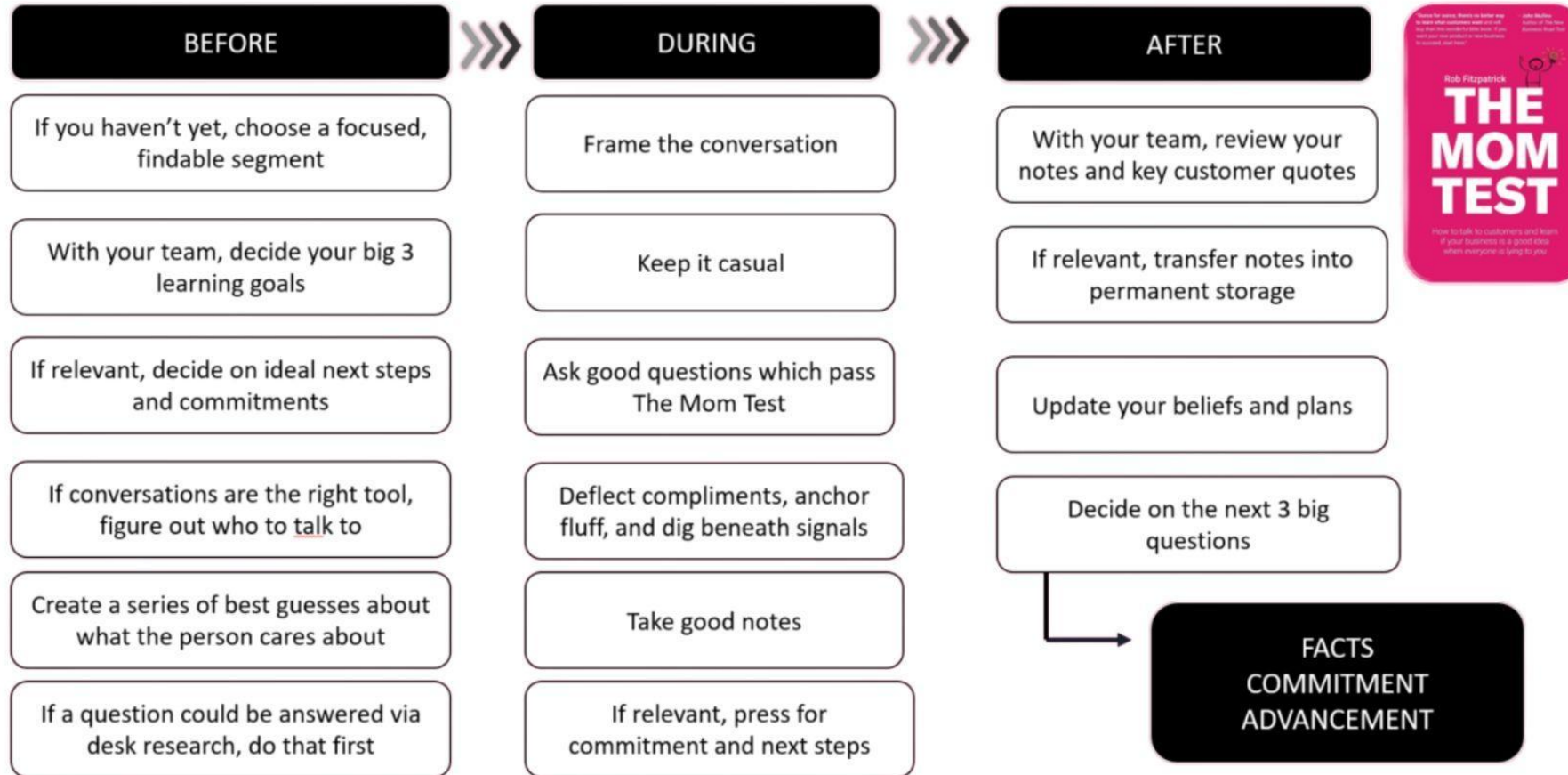
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Your interview should
**not feel like an
interview** at all.

It should feel like a
conversation

INTERVIEWING BASIC TIPS

GOAL

Get a general sense of which value proposition(s) and concept ideas to solve for the value proposition are worth further exploration.

TEMPLATE

- 1) Does the problem exist?
- 2) How do people currently get around the problem?
- 3) How appealing is my solution/value proposition?

DO'S

- ☐ Start/end with thanking them for their time/ build report
- ☐ Introduce your team, project & the
- ☐ Purpose of your research
- ☐ Ask for permission to record/take notes
- ☐ Always make participants feel comfortable, safe, & in control of what they want to disclose
- ☐ Listen and give people time to think, allowing for silence and pauses
- ☐ Protect people's identity and confidential data or stories
- ☐ Tell them how useful their insight will be and emphasize that everything they say is 100% anonymou

DON'TS

- ☐ Finish people's sentences or correct them
- ☐ Pitch or sell ideas, try to convince them
- ☐ Talk about your own opinions or knowledge of the topic
- ☐ Use/look at a computer or phone while you are interviewing, stay focused on them

Create Your Interview Guide

Objective: Prepare for real-world discovery interviews.

Instructions. Please draft:

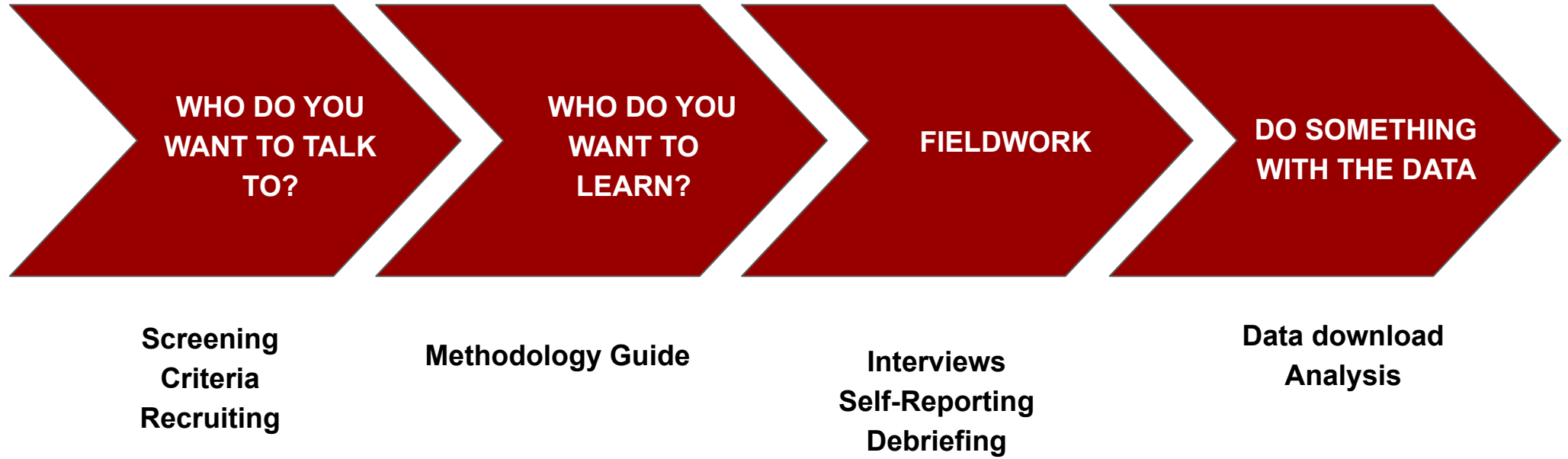
- 2–3 key *learning goals* (What do I want to understand?)
- 5–7 open-ended, past-behavior-based questions

Discuss your strategy in a group.

TYPES OF INTERVIEWS

1. **Generative:** You're interviewing people so that you can come up with new ideas.
1. **Evaluative:** You're interviewing people so that you can see if solutions are desirable / valuable.

INTERVIEW PROCESS



INTERVIEWING BASIC TIPS

Tell me about a time when...

Ask participants to tell a story about an actual event in their past (e.g., “tell me about a recent time when you were impressed with customer service”)

Go deeper, ask ‘why’

Ask ‘why’ questions in response to consecutive answers. This encourages the participant to examine and express their underlying reasons for their behavior and attitudes.

Show me

If you are in the participant’s environment ask them to show you the things they interact with or reference (objects, spaces, tools, websites, apps, etc.)

INTERVIEWING BASIC TIPS

Think aloud/Walk me through it...

As participants perform a process or execute a specific task, ask them to describe aloud what they are thinking. This helps uncover motivations, concerns, perceptions, and reasoning.

Ask open-ended questions

Instead of “Do you like this?” or “Do you like Nike or Adidas”, ask “What do you think of this?” or “What are your favorite sportswear brands?”.

Ask naive questions

When interviewing customers, sometimes it can be useful to ask naïve or seemingly obvious questions. The responses are often unexpected.

INTERVIEWING BASIC TIPS

Encourage but **don't influence.**

If you stay *too* quiet, some people might start getting uncomfortable, thinking that they are boring you or you are judging them.

You can keep things rolling with little motions of encouragement, such as nods, “I see”, “interesting”, etc. But do not say things that might steer or influence the interviewee.

AVOID LEADING QUESTIONS

DON'T SAY: How angry were you when the app didn't start up properly?

DO SAY: What were you feeling when the app didn't start up properly?

“Bad to Better” Question Rewrite

Objective: Learn to spot and fix leading, biased, or hypothetical questions.

Instructions:

- Look at 5 "bad" customer questions
- Rewrite each one following *The Mom Test* principles.
- Share and discuss as a group.

Example:

- ❌ “Would you pay for this?”
- ✅ “Have you paid for something like this before? What was it?”

1. **Would you use this if we built it?**
2. **Do you like the idea?**
3. **How much would you pay for this?**
4. **Would this be useful to you?**
5. **Do you think others would be interested in this?**

✗ Bad Question

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INTERVIEWING BASIC TIPS

Asking about motivations: What have you been experiencing that made you seek out our software?

Asking about problems & struggling moments: Tell me about when you were trying to write your business plan? What was that like?

Asking about the value they receive from your product:

- Exactly what does our software help you do X?
- What were you feeling while using the product?
- When you found our solution, how did that make you feel?
- What were you feeling when you decided to switch to us?

INTERVIEWING BASIC TIPS

Try to hear things you don't want to hear.

If you don't do this, you might find yourself selling or convincing, or even hearing what you want to hear.

**Remember, the goal in this early stage is learning & validation
/invalidation, not a sale.**

SEPARATE BEHAVIOUR & FEEDBACK

Decide up front if your focus is going to be on learning a user's **behavior and mindset**, and/or getting direct feedback or usability insights on a product or mockup.

Do not mix the two in the discussion flow or things will get distorted.

Any questions?



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